

Axiology: Value Theory

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The question: What is a value, where does value reside, how is value recognised and fulfilled, and what makes one evaluation correct and another mistaken? How does the Co-existentialism of Shri A. Nagraj compare with Advaita Vedanta, modern Western value theory, and the natural and social sciences?

This study examines value, evaluation, and the ordering of values in **Madhyasth Darshan** (Co-existentialism), as presented by **Shri A. Nagraj**, and compares its answers with **Advaita Vedanta**, **modern Western axiology and metaethics**, and **the natural and social sciences**.

[The Ontology of Coexistence](#) supplies the setting: Omnipresence, saturated units, form, properties, essential nature and *dharma*, the four orders, and the active structure of *jeevan*. [The Epistemology of Coexistence](#) supplies the sequence of knowing, believing, recognising, fulfilling, and evaluating. The present study asks the specifically axiological questions those two leave open. If a unit's essential nature already is its value, what work is left for evaluation? If value is objective, why does the darshan insist that only awakening evaluates correctly? And if happiness, peace, contentment, and bliss cannot be traded against one another, what kind of ordering do values have at all?

Madhyasth Darshan's value vocabulary is also used by several specialised studies in this collection. Ethics takes up justice, *dharma*, and right-use as conduct; Aesthetics takes up beauty and the aesthetic addition to useful things; Prosperity takes up production, exchange, and accumulation; Family Relationships takes up the individual relationship values in family life. This paper stays at the level those studies presuppose: what a value is, what kinds there are, how the kinds are ordered, and what makes an evaluation true.

Standpoint and scope

These studies are written from the standpoint of a **scientist and technologist** — someone trained to graduate-level **physics and mathematics**, at home with contemporary cosmology, quantum theory, conservation laws, and the logic of formal models.

From that background, a familiar picture of value is hard to avoid: **value appears to be something minds add to a valueless world** — a preference, a reward signal, a fitness proxy, or a social convention projected onto facts that contain none. Modern science is powerful on mechanism, measurement, and prediction; yet the is–ought gap, the status of well-being, and the question of whether anything is good independently of being wanted remain unresolved. The standpoint taken here does not treat those gaps as settled in favour of the view that value is merely projected.

The work begins where that picture leaves open questions and asks whether Madhyasth Darshan offers a coherent alternative worth examining seriously. This paper reads the primary texts and states what

follows from the darshan itself. It then compares that account with **physics and the natural and social sciences**, **Advaita Vedanta**, and **modern Western philosophy**, especially axiology, metaethics, welfare theory, and the economics of value. Physics and mathematics are **one leg** of that comparison, not the only one. The aim is rigorous comparative understanding — testing definitions, internal consistency, and fit with public knowledge — not persuasion or devotional endorsement.

These topical studies state the philosophy in clear, checkable prose first. A separate formal mathematical treatment may follow once the definitions and relations are stable across the studies; this paper does not assume or require that treatment.

1. The Madhyasth Darshan Answer

Madhyasth Darshan holds that value is not conferred by preference, command, or convention. A unit's value is its essentiality as it participates in coexistence, and value is present in every unit whether insentient or sentient. Evaluation occurs through *jeevan*: SB describes recognition of essential nature in the animal order as evaluation, while the knowledge order can make evaluation explicit, test it against human essentiality, and carry it in an awakened tradition. Value is therefore universally distributed, whereas fully correct and communicable evaluation depends on human awakening.

1.1 What value is: essentiality and participation

1.1.1 Value as essentiality

Samadhanatmak Bhautikvad derives value from the ontology directly rather than introducing it as a separate moral topic. Existence is coexistence; every unit exists with beingness; and beingness in mutuality shows itself as complementarity, mutual recognition, and impression. Value enters at exactly that point:

“Entire beingness implies the essentiality of units in every plane and order. Essentiality refers to value.”

— SB, p. 50

Essentiality (*maulikta*) is what a unit distinctively is in the whole — the reading of form, properties, essential nature, and *dharma* developed in [The Ontology of Coexistence](#) §1.3. To say that essentiality is value is to deny that value is an extra property layered on top of natural properties. It is the same fact described from the side of participation. SB restates this as a general claim about units:

“Value is established in every unit. Dharma is inseparable from the unit.”

— SB, p. 87

Essential nature manifests as values in every unit, insentient or sentient, and it is understood through cause and effect rather than by measurement alone (SB, p. 87). SB adds that value is what gets reciprocated: complementarity, mutual recognition, and impression occur only in mutuality, so the essen-

tiality of a unit is “regulated, protected, and universal because it is eternally present” (SB, p. 50). Value is thus relational without being subjective. It requires mutuality, not an observer’s approval. *Manav Karm Darshan* makes the same identification from the side of presence and meaning, and draws the consequence that there is no value-free relation:

“There is no contact or relationship devoid of value.”

— KD, p. 20

KD also states that presence is itself fundamental distinctiveness, value, and meaning, and that the complete meaning of any meaning is realisation (KD, p. 23). Value, meaning, and distinctiveness are three names for one feature of a unit’s being present in coexistence. This is why the darshan can speak of the value of soil, of a medicine, of a relationship, and of *jeevan* without equivocation: in each case it names what that unit distinctively contributes to the order it belongs to.

1.1.2 The ontological synthesis: Form, properties, essential nature, and *dharma*

The darshan grounds value in an explicit fourfold ontology of units: form (*roop*), properties (*guna*), essential nature (*swabhav*), and inseparable identity (*dharma*). Form names the physical structure, boundary, and appearance; properties name the interactive effects (attraction, repulsion, composition, decomposition); essential nature names the characteristic disposition or mode of participation; and *dharma* names the unit’s intrinsic, non-separable beingness.

Essentiality (*maulikta*) is the unified synthesis of *swabhav* and *dharma* as expressed in mutuality. When form and properties operate in alignment with essential nature and *dharma*, the unit’s participation in its environment manifests its value (*mulya*). Value is therefore not an extrinsic rating bestowed by an observer or a projection of subjective desire; it is the expression of *swabhav* and *dharma* in mutuality.

MVD makes the practical reach of this identification explicit in the equation “Sentiment = Essentiality = Value = Responsibility and Participation = Outcome = Evaluation” (MVD, p. 125). The equation does not make value and evaluation temporally identical. It connects what a unit is, the responsibility and participation appropriate to it, the resulting conduct, and the evaluation of that result within one account.

1.1.3 Value as participation in orderliness

Essentiality answers what value is for a unit. Participation answers what value amounts to at the human level. The darshan’s summary formula for humaneness is orderliness with human-ness together with participation in the overall orderliness (MVD, p. 15). Human value is therefore not a private state but a place occupied in a widening order — self, family, society, and universal orderliness.

The practical sequence is stated as a chain: from sociality comes need; from need come use and production; from use and production comes earning; and from earning come use and right-use (MVD, p. 55). Sociality itself is defined by value-fulfilment:

“Sociality (samajikta): - Fulfilling the values inherent in relationships and contacts it-self is sociality.”

— MVD, p. 56

Two things follow. First, value-talk in this darshan is never merely evaluative commentary on conduct; it describes what a relationship is for. Second, human value cannot be assessed in isolation from participation. The five dimensions of social orderliness — education–*sanskar*, justice–preservation, health–restraint, production–work, exchange–storage — are therefore institutional forms through which value can be fulfilled ([The Ontology of Coexistence](#) §1.15). MVD’s definition of fulfilment includes use, right-use, and purposeful-use, so value-fulfilment concerns both the handling of things and the purposes served.

1.1.4 Value across the four orders and ecological right-use

Since value is the essentiality of any unit, the material, pranic, animal, and knowledge orders all have value. The first two orders recognise and fulfil through structural or seed conformance, without reflective choice. The animal order includes *jeevan*, and SB describes its recognition of essential nature — especially friendliness and opposition — as evaluation. The knowledge order adds knowing and believing before action, explicit evaluation of fulfilment, and the possibility of correcting evaluation through awakening ([The Epistemology of Coexistence](#) §1.5).

The human being is therefore uniquely responsible for conscious right-use without being the source of value. SB states that under delusion humans exploit nature other than humans, while upon realisation of seer-status they appear as nurturers (SB, p. 200). Evaluation of natural treasure is to proceed by usefulness, with use and right-use proportionate to natural regeneration (SB, p. 141). This grounds ecological responsibility in the essentiality of the other orders rather than solely in calculated human interest.

1.2 The principal classes of value

1.2.1 A working taxonomy

Jeevan Vidya names the value classes a human being has to comprehend:

“By comprehending human values, jeevan values, established values, and civic values, concerns about profit and loss vanish.”

— JV, p. 43

“Object value is spread everywhere, while jeevan values, human values, and established values are inherent to jeevan, and jeevan itself performs their evaluation.”

— JV, p. 139

The translations do not present one simple numbered taxonomy. JV, p. 43 names human, *jeevan*, established, and civic values; JV, p. 139 contrasts object value, which is “spread everywhere,” with *jeevan*, human, and established values, which are inherent to *jeevan*. MVD, p. 305 names *jeevan*, human, es-

tablished, *shishta*, and usefulness–aesthetic values. In that passage the English translation renders *shishta mulya* as “civic values.” This study therefore treats expressed and civic values as two English descriptions of the same class: the civilised expression of values in behaviour and participation.

Class	Locus	Primary articulation	Evidence of fulfilment
Object, usefulness, and aesthetic value (<i>vastu/upayogita/kala mulya</i>)	Physical units and produced objects	What a thing can do, with aesthetic value added through useful design	Use, right-use, and purposeful-use
<i>Jeevan</i> values	<i>Jeevan</i> , borne at <i>mun</i> , <i>vritti</i> , <i>chitta</i> , and <i>buddhi</i>	Happiness, peace, contentment, and bliss as harmonies among adjacent faculties	Continuity of harmony
Human values (<i>manav mulya</i>)	<i>Jeevan</i> in the human joint form, at positions in <i>vritti</i> and <i>mun</i>	Happiness as <i>dharma</i> and the six dispositions of human essential nature	Humaneness in thought, behaviour, work, and participation
Established values (<i>sthapit mulya</i>)	<i>Jeevan</i> , at positions in <i>chitta</i> , <i>vritti</i> , and <i>mun</i> ; evidenced in recognised relationships	Care, guidance, trust, affection, gratitude, glory, love, reverence, and respect	Fulfilment of the relationship’s inherent expectation and mutual satisfaction
<i>Shishta</i> or civic values	<i>Jeevan</i> , at the same positions as the established values they express	The paired expression of established values in conduct	Participation in family, society, and orderliness

The locus column follows the passage quoted above: object value is spread everywhere, while the other four classes are inherent to *jeevan*, which also evaluates them (JV, p. 139). The primary texts make that inherence precise. Each named value of those four classes is defined in the appendix that defines *jeevan*’s activities, where it occupies a position at one of the five faculties beside the term through which it is expressed (MVD, pp. 328–348; AVD, pp. 91–94). A named value is accordingly an activity of a faculty rather than a disposition standing beside *jeevan*’s activity. The placement does not make the class taxonomy redundant: a value belongs to a class by the evaluative question it answers and to a position by the faculty that bears it, and neither assignment is derived from the other (Editorial Notes). Nor does it make value private, since what *jeevan* bears becomes evident only where the relationship is recognised (§1.4.1). The enumeration is set out position by position in [The Sixty-One Activity Pairs of Jeevan](#).

Human living also spans realisation, thought, behaviour, and work/production. The value classes appear across these dimensions, but the primary passages do not supply a one-to-one mapping. Object value is addressed chiefly in work and right-use, relational values in behaviour, and *jeevan* values in the inner activities, while human and civic value integrate all four. JV emphasises that evaluating the values inherent to *jeevan* needs no external apparatus: it is examining the self, by the self, and for the self (JV, p. 139).

1.2.2 The four *jeevan* values as harmonies

The four *jeevan* values are defined structurally, as harmonies between adjacent faculties, not as pleasant sensations of varying intensity:

“Among the values, jeevan values are known by the names - happiness, peace, contentment and bliss, which are only names of the state of harmony within jeevan.”
— JV, p. 138

<i>Jeevan</i> value	Borne at	Harmony between	Evidenced socially as
Happiness (<i>sukh</i>)	<i>mun</i>	<i>mun</i> and <i>vritti</i>	Resolution in the individual
Peace (<i>shanti</i>)	<i>vritti</i>	<i>vritti</i> and <i>chitta</i>	Resolution with prosperity in the family
Contentment (<i>santosh</i>)	<i>chitta</i>	<i>chitta</i> and <i>buddhi</i>	Fearlessness through participation in society
Bliss (<i>anand</i>)	<i>buddhi</i>	<i>buddhi</i> and <i>atma</i>	Coexistence, and the communication of understanding

Each of the four is at the same time a named activity borne by the outer faculty of its pair (MVD, pp. 328–346). The two descriptions are one account given twice. Peace is defined at *vritti* as the absence of resistance between desire and thought, which are the orientations of *chitta* and *vritti*, so what the pair formulation states from outside the position states from within the faculty that bears it. Happiness at *mun* is defined simply as resolution, which is why sustained dissatisfaction bears on the whole ladder rather than counting as a passing mood. Realisation in coexistence at *atma* is ultimate bliss (*paramanand*), whose effect reaches the remaining faculties (MVD, pp. 100–101); it grounds the four rather than adding a fifth to the enumeration. A harmony is therefore established in a faculty rather than delivered to it, and its failure is a failure of concurrence with the faculty below.

Two consequences matter for value theory. First, because each value names harmony between a distinct pair of faculties, no amount of one directly constitutes another. A person may have abundant sensory satisfaction and no peace; the darshan states that sensory satisfaction does not necessarily lead to the heart’s satisfaction, though the reverse does hold (MVD, p. 67). This supports a non-substitutability reading, although the separate higher–lower ordering leaves open whether the system permits an overall standard (§7.1). Second, these values are not produced by acquisition. MVD defines content-

ment as “the lack of the sentiment of lacking” (MVD, p. 331) — an absence of deficiency-sentiment, not an accumulated quantity.

The harmonies also stand in a definite relation to the four human goals. Resolution is evidenced as happiness; peace becomes evident with resolution and prosperity in family living; contentment through orderly participation in society; and bliss in the course of living and communicating understanding ([The Ontology of Coexistence](#) §1.15). Inner value and outward condition are two readings of one achievement, which is why the darshan refuses both a purely private account of well-being and a purely institutional one.

1.2.3 Human values: the *dharma* and essential nature of the human being

Human value is stated as a *dharma* together with an essential nature:

“The Dharma of humans is happiness, and their essential nature is fortitude, courage, generosity, kindness, grace and compassion.”

— MVD, p. 125

MVD adds the identity “Sentiment = Essentiality” on the same page, and defines essential nature as the value of self with reflective sentiment (MVD, p. 124). Human value is thus not a code imposed on human beings; it is what a human being innately is, expressed as disposition.

The six terms of essential nature are separately defined, and three of them are distinguished by a criterion that is easy to miss — whether the recipient lacks the resource, the receptivity, or both.

Term	Definition	Distinguishing condition
Fortitude (<i>dhirata</i>)	Dedication and firmness towards justice (MVD, p. 52)	—
Courage (<i>virata</i>)	Deploying one’s intellectual and physical powers to make justice available to others (MVD, p. 52)	—
Generosity (<i>udarta</i>)	Offering body, mind, and wealth as per need for another’s awakening, health, and prosperity, and experiencing happiness thereby (MVD, p. 340)	—
Kindness (<i>daya</i>)	The endeavour of making content available to those who have receptivity but lack the content (MVD, p. 61)	Receptivity present, content absent
Grace (<i>kripa</i>)	The endeavour of instilling receptivity in those for whom content is available but receptivity or humane perspective is lacking (MVD, p. 61)	Content present, receptivity absent
Compassion (<i>karuna</i>)	The endeavour of making both available to those who have neither (MVD, p. 61)	Both absent

This is characteristic of the darshan’s method: what other traditions treat as gradations of warmth are here separated by the objective condition of the person one is acting toward. The distinction matters axiologically because it makes these dispositions answerable to a fact about the situation rather than to the intensity of the agent’s feeling. MVD elsewhere compresses all three into love, defined as the combined expression of kindness, grace, and compassion (MVD, p. 331).

The six are named in the activity enumeration as well, though not all in the same way. Courage with fortitude, and grace with compassion, occupy positions of their own at *vritti*; kindness is the expression paired with peace at *vritti*, and generosity the expression paired with care at *mun* (MVD, pp. 331–340; AVD, pp. 91–94). Class and position accordingly cut across each other rather than lining up, which is the point §1.2.1 records: a value that answers a human-value question can occupy a position whose other member answers a *jeevan*-value or established-value one.

1.2.4 Object value: usefulness, aesthetic addition, and symbol

Object value is treated as a distinct class. JV states its constancy:

“The object value remains constant. For example, whatever value (usefulness) is there in one kilogram sesame seeds, it has always been the same. Similarly, the value of medicine, rice, wheat, vegetables, etc also remains constant. This is called usefulness value.”

— JV, p. 137

The same passage adds a second kind for produced things: in cars, trains, and the like, aesthetic value gets added, and aesthetics is meaningful when it adds convenience to usefulness (JV, pp. 137–138). Aesthetics is therefore presented as a qualification of usefulness; [Aesthetics](#) §4.1 develops the point.

Against these stands symbolic value:

“The accumulation is only of money, which is symbolic value.”

— MVD, p. 183

Kind	What it tracks	Status in the darshan
Usefulness value (<i>upyogita mulya</i>)	The capacities through which an object can serve a purpose	The real value of the object; described as constant in JV
Aesthetic value (<i>kala/saundarya mulya</i>)	Convenience and beauty added to usefulness in produced things	Genuine when integrated with usefulness
Symbolic value (<i>prateek mulya</i>)	Money as a token of exchange	Accumulable, but not the usefulness or aesthetic value of an object

The constancy claim is best read as constancy of the object’s relevant capacity rather than equal usefulness in every context. The primary passage does not state that distinction, and §7.5 examines the difficulty.

1.3 Relational and social value

1.3.1 Relationship, contact, and definite expectation

Before the values inherent in relationships can be stated, the darshan has to say what a relationship is. It does so by a single criterion — whether the expectations in a mutuality are fixed or chosen:

“Relationship (sambandh): - The mutuality where expectations are predetermined in the sense of completeness, such union is referred to as relationship.”

— MVD, p. 62

“Contact (sampark): - The mutuality where expectations are voluntary, such union is referred to as contact.”

— MVD, p. 61

This is what makes a relationship definite in Madhyasth Darshan. Its expectations are not negotiated by the parties and do not vary with their preferences; they are given with the relationship, in the sense of what completeness requires of it. Contact is not a lesser or defective case but the other kind of mutuality, in which the parties do settle what they expect of each other. Both carry value, since no contact or relationship is devoid of value (KD, p. 20); they differ in whether the expectation is discovered or agreed.

The set of relationships is likewise enumerated rather than left open:

“Relationships are in the form of father-mother and son-daughter, brother-sister, husband-wife, master-associate, guru-disciple, friends, and orderliness relationships.”

— MVD, p. 190

Relationship	Parties	Principal purpose
Parent and child	Father-mother, son-daughter	Nurturing and guidance toward comprehensive resolution
Sibling	Brother-sister	Mutual assurance within the family
Spousal	Husband-wife	Marital faithfulness and shared family living
Master and associate	Employer, co-worker	Work, production, and right-use in mutuality
Teacher and student	<i>Guru</i> , disciple	Transmission of understanding
Friendship	Friends	Complementary assistance without hierarchy
Orderliness	The person and the widening order	Participation in family, society, and universal orderliness

The seventh is the one most easily overlooked and the most consequential for this study. A relationship with orderliness itself, rather than with another person, is what allows participation (§1.1.3) to carry definite expectations rather than remaining a general aspiration. MVD states on the same page that conferred rights are of three kinds — family-conferred, society-conferred, and orderliness-conferred — which ties the relationship set to the same widening order.

1.3.2 Established and *shishta* values in relationship

Established values (*sthapit mulya*) are values inherent in relationships. JV names nine examples:

“Values such as care, guidance, trust, affection, gratitude, glory, love, reverence, and respect form the basis of our interactions.”

— JV, p. 108

MVD’s appendix places each of these terms beside a paired term. Read together with its later reference to *sthapit* and *shishta* values, the pairs show established value and its civilised expression. The appendix does not separately argue for that interpretation, so the table preserves its pairings rather than supplying new ones. The same appendix fixes where each pair stands. Three of the nine are borne at *chitta*, three at *vritti*, and three at *mun*, with the established value borne by the faculty in state and the civic value carrying it outward (AVD, pp. 91–94). The pairings below are therefore not a choice of matching terms; substituting a different expression for any of the nine would depart from the enumeration.

Established value	Borne at	Primary-text definition	Paired <i>shishta</i> or civic value	Expression named in MVD
Care (<i>mamta</i>)	<i>mun</i>	Nurturing and protecting with the pinnacle of affinity (MVD, p. 339)	Generosity (<i>udarta</i>)	Offering body, mind, and wealth for another’s awakening, health, and prosperity
Guidance (<i>vatsalya</i>)	<i>chitta</i>	Continued nurturing and protection for comprehensive resolution (MVD, p. 331)	Naturalness / effortlessness (<i>sahajta</i>)	Clarity, authenticity, and integrality of behaviour, norm, thought, and realisation
Trust (<i>vishwas</i>)	<i>vritti</i>	Fulfilment of values inherent in mutuality (MVD, p. 335)	Concordance (<i>saujanya</i>)	Collaboration, co-participation, cooperation, and complementariness
Affection (<i>sneha</i>)	<i>mun</i>	Absence of resistance in just behaviour; willing meeting in satisfaction (MVD, p. 340)	Dedication (<i>nishtha</i>)	Continuing effort to attain and evidence the goal of awakening

Established value	Borne at	Primary-text definition	Paired <i>shishta</i> or civic value	Expression named in MVD
Gratitude (<i>kritagyata</i>)	<i>vrutti</i>	Acceptance of help received for development and awakening (MVD, p. 335)	Humility (<i>saumyata</i>)	Willing self-restraint and establishment in civility
Glory (<i>gaurav</i>)	<i>vrutti</i>	Embracing emulation without resistance (MVD, p. 335)	Simplicity (<i>saralta</i>)	Demeanour free of complexity and tension
Love (<i>prem</i>)	<i>chitta</i>	Realisation of the complete; combined expression of kindness, grace, and compassion (MVD, p. 331)	Non-otherness (<i>ananyata</i>)	Complementarity in human mutuality and with the rest of nature
Reverence (<i>shraddha</i>)	<i>chitta</i>	Movement towards qualitative transformation, awakening, and authenticity (MVD, pp. 331–332)	Devoutness (<i>pujyata</i>)	Activeness for qualitative development and awakening
Respect (<i>samman</i>)	<i>mun</i>	Acceptance of personality and talent, and their balanced exposition (MVD, p. 340)	Cordiality (<i>sauhardta</i>)	Presenting conception, realisation, memory, and direct recognition as accepted

Three features of this relational architecture bear on the theory. First, none of the definitions is affective. Each names an activity, an acceptance, or a movement whose success conditions lie in the relationship rather than in the agent’s inner warmth. Trust in particular is defined as *fulfilment*, not as confidence — a striking departure from most philosophical treatments of trust as an attitude under uncertainty.

Second, the values are not to be acquired from outside. JV states that values are inherent in *jeevan* and are deployed when relationships are recognised, using the case of a mother who needs no plan to feel care once she has recognised her child (JV, p. 138). Where relationships are not recognised, there is no flow of values (JV, p. 55).

Third, the texts provide one dependency sequence without deriving a complete ordering of all nine examples. JV says that with gratitude the other values begin to manifest (JV, p. 108). MVD states a longer chain:

“Gratitude leads to glory, glory leads to simplicity, simplicity leads to effortlessness, effortlessness leads to humaneness, humaneness leads to coexistence, and gratitude arises in, by, and for coexistence.”

— MVD, p. 38

The chain closes on itself: gratitude begins this sequence and also arises from coexistence, its terminus. It describes a cycle sustained by realisation, not an exhaustive rank-order of relationship values.

1.3.3 From relationship values to social participation

The translations' "civic values" are best read as *shishṭa mūlyā*: the civilised expression of values in contact, relationship, work, and public participation, rather than a second independent list. Their social field includes the five dimensions of education–*sanskara*, justice–preservation, health–restraint, production–work, and exchange–storage. Through these, relationship values extend from family living to Undivided Society (*Akhaṇḍ Samaj*) and Universal Orderliness (*Sarvabhāva Vyavasthā*).

1.4 Recognition, fulfilment, and evaluation

1.4.1 Recognition, fulfilment, evaluation, mutual satisfaction

Values are recognised, not created. JV states the condition plainly:

"Values are realised through the recognition of relationships."

— JV, p. 55

The full activity has four steps, and MVD's appendix gives them as the definition of justice (*nyaya*), alongside its other gloss of justice as the acts carried out for nurturing, growth, and evaluation of humaneness:

"Recognition of relationships, Fulfilling of values, Evaluation, and Mutual satisfaction."

— MVD, p. 336

SB gives the same sequence and identifies it with awakening rather than with rule-following: justice in humans, as the activities of recognising relationships, fulfilling values, and evaluating, is itself awakening (SB, p. 114). SB also lists the ability to recognise relationships, fulfil values, and perform evaluation among the attributes universally accessible to human beings (SB, pp. 122, 134).

Each step can fail independently, building an account of moral failure from operational breakdowns rather than weakness of will. A person may fail to recognise a relationship, lack the capacity to fulfil it, or evaluate the result wrongly. Satisfaction may also arise on one side only. The text names *mutual* satisfaction (*ubhaya tripti*) as the terminus, so one-sided satisfaction does not complete the sequence. This makes a simple preference-satisfaction reading inadequate.

1.4.2 Evaluation as sentiment activity and its three failure modes

Evaluation has a technical name and a technical location. MVD assigns values and evaluation together to *bhava-kriyā*, and makes their correctness depend on the evaluator:

“The process of values and evaluation is referred to as the ‘sentiment activity’, which operates by distinguishing between real and unreal, based on the evaluator’s state of awakening or delusion.”

— MVD, p. 203

The glossary confirms the close connection: sentiment (*bhav*) is glossed as “Value, evaluation” (MVD, p. 326). The text places value as content and evaluation as determination within a single sentiment activity without erasing their conceptual difference.

Correctness then has a single stated condition and three named failures:

“The correct evaluation occurs only through awakening with complete understanding; otherwise, under-evaluation, over-evaluation or mis-evaluation takes place.”

— MVD, p. 203

SB states the same triad as the manifestation of delusion (SB, p. 146): - **Over-evaluation (*adhimulyan*)**: Assigning greater value or capability to a person, object, or relationship than its essentiality warrants. - **Under-evaluation (*avamulyan*)**: Assigning lesser value or capability than its essentiality warrants. - **Mis-evaluation (*amulyan*)**: Assigning a completely wrong or inverted category of value (e.g. treating money as intrinsic wealth, or relationship as mere transaction).

1.4.3 Self-evaluation, conceit, attachment, and dispassion

MVD calls self-evaluation (*swa-mulyankan*) the first and foremost step in human development (MVD, p. 87). The primary passages do not establish a technical opposite called *par-mulyankan*. Their contrast is between correct self-evaluation against human essentiality and imposed or mistaken evaluation under delusion. Three terms clarify that contrast: - **Conceit (*abhimān*)**: Imposed evaluation (*aropit mulyankan*), characterized by over-evaluation, under-evaluation, or mis-evaluation (MVD, pp. 38, 185). - **Attachment (*asakti*)**: Believing mistakes made towards decline to be correct (MVD, p. 124). - **Dispassion (*vairagya*)**: Defined negatively and precisely:

“Dispassion means freedom from attachment, which is being without the flaws of over-evaluation, under-evaluation and mis-evaluation.”

— MVD, p. 152

Dispassion is therefore not indifference to value. It is freedom from attachment and from the three evaluative flaws, supported by steady self-evaluation.

1.4.4 The rooting chain

MVD states the dependencies among value, evaluation, and language as a chain that returns to its beginning:

“Language has sentiment (bhav) at its root; sentiment has essentiality at its root; essentiality has evaluation at its root; evaluation has worldview at its root; worldview has perceiver at its root; perceiver has capacity, ability and receptivity at its root; capacity, ability and receptivity have the perception, comprehension and awareness of truth at its root; perception, comprehension and awareness of truth have the language at its root.”

— MVD, p. 83

The passage closes by naming all of these as activities of *chitta*, which succeed or fail according to the perceiver’s level of awakening. Read as a linear justification the chain is circular: language is grounded in sentiment, and awareness of truth — on which sentiment ultimately rests — is grounded in language. Read as the darshan appears to intend it, the chain is a description of one integrated activity in which no member operates alone, and the variable that determines whether the whole functions is awakening rather than the ordering of the members.

1.4.5 The six perspectives as evaluative ordering and higher/lower value dynamics

Human behaviour is expressed through six evaluative perspectives:

“All human behaviour is manifest in six perspectives: - (1) pleasant-unpleasant, (2) healthy-unhealthy, (3) profit-loss, (4) justice-injustice, (5) dharma-adharma, and (6) truth-untruth.”

— MVD, p. 67

MVD assigns the first three to the inhumane perspective and the last three to the humane perspective (MVD, pp. 58, 60), and adds a seventh standpoint above both: the higher-humane perspective is “Only Truth” (MVD, p. 61). The humane perspectives supply the standard by which the first three are correctly used; the lower three are not rivals but subordinate instruments.

Alongside the classification of perspectives, the darshan uses a comparative vocabulary of higher and lower value. Its anchor is a definition of profit that inverts the usual one:

“Obtaining a higher value in exchange for a lower value is profit.”

— MVD, p. 67

MVD supplies the content of the comparison: resolved outlook is called higher value (*guru mulya*), and tendency for problems lower value (*laghu mulya*) (MVD, p. 126). The dynamics of movement between them are given their own terms:

Term	Definition	Cited
Mutual ascent (<i>ubhaya sukruti</i>)	Movement towards attaining higher value and long-lasting result or permanence, and awakening	MVD, pp. 44, 110

Term	Definition	Cited
Mutual descent (<i>ubhaya vikruti</i>)	Movement towards lower value or short-lasting result and decline	MVD, p. 110
Inspiration (<i>prerna</i>)	Movement towards mutual ascent upon coming together	MVD, p. 110
Retrogression (<i>pratikranti</i>)	Movement towards mutual descent upon coming together	MVD, p. 110
Ascension cause	Progress from lower-value to higher-value result, maturation, and consequence	MVD, p. 219
Descension cause	Movement from higher-value to lower-value result, maturation, and consequence	MVD, p. 219

Durability is one mark within the comparison: higher value is paired with long-lasting result, lower value with short-lasting result. It is not the only stated criterion. The contrast also concerns resolved versus problem-oriented outlook, awakening versus decline, and ascent versus descent. How these marks combine remains open (§7.1). MVD also states that “It is natural for a lower value to be attracted towards a higher value” (MVD, p. 222).

1.4.6 What makes an evaluation correct

The darshan holds both that value is objective and that evaluation is correct only under awakening. The texts resolve this apparent tension by making the *standard* of evaluation the essentiality of the thing evaluated, and awakening the *condition* under which that standard is accessible.

SB states the standard for the human case:

“The natural state refers to the essentiality of humans, i.e. human-ness. It is on this basis alone that humans could be rightly evaluated.”

— SB, p. 201

Since essentiality is value (§1.1.1), correct evaluation is recognition of what the unit already is, and the three failure modes of §1.4.2 are three ways of misdescribing it. SB holds that values and existence are recognised only through *jeevan*, and that humans express, communicate, and evaluate values only upon awakening (SB, p. 64). Value is not derived from preference, command, or non-natural property; it is what a unit essentially is, and evaluation is a cognitive achievement about a real subject matter.

1.5 Conduct, continuity, and evidence

1.5.1 Value, character, and ethics

Humane conduct is presented as a compound of three things, with value first:

“In this way, humane conduct is explained as the combined form of values, character, and ethics.”

— JV, p. 55

KD gives the same formula and adds that only on the basis of fundamental distinctiveness does the evaluation of values come to be (KD, p. 67). JV specifies the other two members concretely: character (*charitra*) is rightfully owned wealth, marital faithfulness, and kindness in work and behaviour; ethics (*niti*) is the right-use and protection of resources in the form of body, mind, and wealth (JV, p. 55).

In this darshan axiology is not a branch of ethics but its presupposition: character and ethics are what value-fulfilment looks like in disposition and in the handling of resources. *Ethics and Morals in Human Beings* develops character and right-use. The structural point here is that “what is valuable” cannot be settled by a separate ethical theory, because humane conduct is already specified through values recognised in relationships.

1.5.2 Practical value, self-value, balance, and *sanskar*

Value determination is assigned to specific activities of *jeevan*. KD states that practical values are determined through deliberation (*vichar*), become meaningful in humaneness, and are “stable value” (KD, pp. 16, 20). It defines self-value as the satisfaction of activity and cessation (KD, p. 46), and elsewhere places relationship, value, evaluation, and balance in one sequence (KD, p. 51). These formulations connect the stability of value with fulfilment and with the balance evidenced in conduct; they do not introduce another independent value class.

Taste (*asvadan*), the activity of *mun*, savours value once it is fulfilled. JV states that when taste has value-fulfilment, those values receive names such as love, trust, affection, gratitude, and guidance (JV, p. 138). MVD’s appendix organises the wider vocabulary into two activities of *atma*, four of *buddhi*, sixteen of *chitta*, thirty-six of *vritti*, and sixty-four of *mun* (MVD, pp. 328–343). Those counts run two to a position, so the same enumeration reads as one position at *atma*, two at *buddhi*, eight at *chitta*, eighteen at *vritti*, and thirty-two at *mun* — sixty-one positions and a hundred and twenty-two named activities (AVD, pp. 91–94). Every value named in §§1.2–1.3 is a member of it. The appendix also defines states, relations, kinds, sensory qualities, and bodily correlates, so the containment runs one way only: not every member is itself a value.

Values feed back into *sanskar* through evaluated result. Karma has result; result returns to the knower through evaluation; and repeated action and evaluation shape *sanskar*, which conditions later projection ([The Epistemology of Coexistence](#) §1.5). MVD divides *sanskar* into *susanskar* under awakening and *kusanskar* under delusion (MVD, p. 315). *Susanskar* represents tendencies aligned with awakening that promote resolution and prosperity (MVD, p. 94). This creates a closed circuit: understanding projects as conduct; conduct produces result; result is evaluated; evaluation settles as acceptance (*sanskar*); and that acceptance drives further awakening.

1.5.3 Method, evidence, and what Madhyasth Darshan establishes

The axiological claims do not all warrant the same kind of assent: - **Definitional claims:** essentiality is value (SB, p. 50); sentiment is value and evaluation (MVD, p. 326); justice is the four-step sequence

(MVD, p. 336); humane conduct is value, character, and ethics (JV, p. 55). These are assessed for coherence and internal consistency. - **Structural interpretations:** the non-substitutability reading of the four harmonies; flow of values upon recognition of relationship; division of *jeevan*'s activities under delusion versus awakening. These can be checked against the texts and human experience without being treated as definitions. - **Evaluative correctness claims:** awakening as condition for correct evaluation. These are the darshan's core philosophical commitments. - **Social/economic claims:** constancy of usefulness value; money as symbolic value; profitability redefined as higher-for-lower exchange. These face empirical testing (§7.5).

2. The Advaita Vedanta Answer

Advaita Vedanta holds that value in the ordinary sense belongs to the empirical order and is finally superseded. What is unconditionally valuable is not an object, a relationship, or a state of affairs but the Self, which is already of the nature of bliss. The tradition therefore has a rich account of values as qualification and as expression, and a principled reason for denying that anything in the world is valuable in its own right.

2.1 The *purusharthas* and their ordering

Classical Vedanta inherits the fourfold scheme of human ends — *dharma*, *artha*, *kama*, and *moksha* — and ranks *moksha* as the *parama-purushartha*, the end beyond which nothing is sought. The first three are legitimate within the empirical order and are ordered among themselves, with *dharma* regulating the pursuit of wealth and pleasure. The decisive Advaitic move is not the ranking but the difference in kind: *artha* and *kama* are attained and lost, *dharma* produces results within time, while *moksha* is not produced at all. Shankara's *Brahma Sutra Bhashya* treats liberation as eternally accomplished and merely obscured by ignorance, so the highest value is not a state to be brought about but a fact to be recognised.

2.2 *Ananda* as nature, not attainment

Brahman is characterised as Existence, Consciousness, and Bliss. In the Taittiriya Upanishad's ascent through the sheaths, *ananda* appears as the innermost, and Shankara reads bliss not as an intense pleasure but as the absence of the limitation that makes pleasure episodic. The *Vivekachudamani*, a later pedagogical witness, states the same identification (v. 152).

The axiological consequence is far-reaching. If the highest value is one's own nature, then no action can produce it and no loss can remove it. Value-seeking, on this account, is structurally mistaken about its own object: what is sought as an outcome is already the seeker. The tradition's positive teaching about happiness is therefore diagnostic rather than prescriptive.

2.3 The Maitreyi passage

The sharpest axiological statement in the corpus is Yajnavalkya's teaching to Maitreyi in the Brihadaranyaka Upanishad (2.4.5). The husband is not dear for the sake of the husband, nor wealth for

the sake of wealth; everything is dear for the sake of the Self. Dearness (*priyata*) has a single source, and its apparent distribution across persons and things is a misattribution.

This is a genuine theory of value, not a devotional flourish. It explains why particular attachments feel unconditional and why they nonetheless disappoint, and it grounds an argument for renunciation that does not depend on calling the world evil. It also marks the deepest divergence from Madhyasth Darshan, which holds that value is distributed among units and that each relationship has its own inherent expectation to fulfil. For Advaita, the plurality of values is a refracted appearance of one value; for Madhyasth Darshan, plurality is real and the four *jeevan* harmonies are irreducibly four.

2.4 Values as qualification

Advaita is exacting about the values a seeker must already have. The *sadhana-chatushtaya* comprises discrimination between the eternal and the non-eternal (*viveka*), dispassion (*vairagya*), the six treasures beginning with tranquillity and self-restraint, and the intense desire for liberation (*mumukshutva*). The *Vivekachudamani* sets out these qualifications and the virtues that support them (vv. 17–20, 69, 82); the Bhagavad Gita's list of divine qualities — non-injury, truthfulness, absence of anger, renunciation, kindness, purity — serves the same function (16.2–16.3).

These are values in a specific role: they qualify a person for knowledge without themselves constituting the goal. Dispassion in particular is instructive to compare. In Advaita, *vairagya* is turning away from what is non-eternal; in Madhyasth Darshan, dispassion is freedom from the three flaws of evaluation (§1.4.3). Both refuse to identify it with indifference, but one defines it by withdrawal and the other by accuracy.

2.5 Action, result, and *loka-sangraha*

The Gita supplies Advaita's practical axiology. Prescribed action is to be performed without attachment to its fruit (3.8), and the enlightened continue to act for the holding-together of the world (3.20, 3.25–26). Shankara reads such action as neither productive of liberation nor obstructive of it.

This yields a stable but thin account of relational value. Conduct matters, and the *jivanmukta*'s conduct is exemplary; but its value is not that a relationship's inherent expectation has been met, since at the level of final truth there are no relata. The tradition's own vocabulary for the world's holding-together is enough to sustain a practical ethics and not enough to ground the value of the world as such.

2.6 Method, evidence, and what Advaita establishes

Advaita's method is *sruti* as the means of knowledge for what is beyond perception and inference, supported by reasoning and by the discipline of hearing, reflection, and sustained contemplation (BU 2.4.5). Its axiological achievements are two. It establishes, with unusual rigour, that a value which can be gained and lost cannot be the final good, and it offers a unified explanation of why finite goods disappoint. What it does not establish, by its own lights, is that the plurality of values in the empirical order is anything other than provisional — and this is a consequence its tradition accepts rather than a gap it seeks to close.

3. Modern Western Axiology and Metaethics

Modern Western philosophy has no single answer about value; it has a well-mapped space of positions and a set of arguments that constrain them. The relevant contrast with the other two traditions is not a doctrine but a method: Western value theory has largely proceeded by isolating questions — Is value objective? Is it reducible to natural facts? Is it one thing or many? — and pursuing each independently.

3.1 Intrinsic, final, and instrumental value

The organising distinction is between what is valuable as a means and what is valuable in itself. Moore's *Principia Ethica* proposed the isolation test: to determine whether something has intrinsic value, imagine it existing alone and ask whether its existence would be good. Later work separated two things Moore ran together — being valuable *for its own sake* (final value) and being valuable *in virtue of intrinsic properties* — since something may be finally valuable partly because of its history or relations. Moore's own doctrine of organic unities already conceded that the value of a whole need not be the sum of the values of its parts.

Two points of contact with §1.1.1 are worth marking. Madhyasth Darshan's identification of value with essentiality resembles a claim about intrinsic value in the second sense, since essentiality is what the unit is. But the darshan also holds that value is what is reciprocated in mutuality (SB, p. 50), which makes it relational in a way the isolation test would not register. And the darshan has no use for the summing of values that organic unities are introduced to correct, because its values are not quantities.

3.2 The is–ought gap and the open question

Hume's observation in the *Treatise* that writers pass from *is* to *ought* without explaining the transition set the modern problem. Moore's open question argument sharpened it: for any proposed natural analysis of goodness — the pleasant, the desired, the more evolved — it remains an open question whether what satisfies the analysis is good, which suggests that the analysis has not captured the concept.

Madhyasth Darshan does not answer these arguments in their own terms; it declines the framing that generates them. If essentiality is value, there is no inference from *is* to *ought* to justify, because the evaluative fact is not a further fact. Whether that is a solution or a redescription is the question raised in §7.4. What can be said here is that the move is not unfamiliar: neo-Aristotelian naturalism makes a structurally similar claim by grounding goodness in the characteristic form of a kind of living thing.

3.3 Realism, constructivism, and expressivism

The main metaethical families can be arranged by what they say about the truth of value judgments. Naturalist realism identifies value properties with natural ones, while non-naturalist realism accepts irreducible normative facts. Constructivism grounds normative truth in agents' standpoints or procedures of practical reason. Expressivism and quasi-realism treat value judgments as expressions of attitude that nonetheless support truth-talk. Error theory holds that value judgments purport to describe

objective values and fail. Each family carries a characteristic cost: reduction risks the open question, non-naturalism epistemic mystery, constructivism loss of mind-independence, expressivism loss of disagreement, and error theory loss of the practice.

Madhyasth Darshan is closest in outcome to a naturalist realism, but it is not a reduction of value to properties describable by the natural sciences. Its natural order includes *jeevan*, essentiality, and *dharma*, none of which is a physical quantity, and its epistemology of value is the knowledge-order activity of a sentient unit rather than perception or inference from measurement. In the Western taxonomy it is best described as a realism whose ontology is not physicalist — a position the taxonomy accommodates but rarely occupies.

3.4 Fitting-attitude accounts, reasons, and response-dependence

An influential family analyses value in terms of the attitudes it would be fitting to take: to be valuable is to be a fitting object of pro-attitudes. Scanlon's buck-passing variant holds that being valuable is not itself a reason-giving property but a way of indicating that other properties provide reasons. Response-dependent accounts make value constitutively connected to idealised human responses.

This is the nearest Western analogue to *bhav-kriya* (§1.4.2), and the comparison is instructive because the direction of dependence differs. On fitting-attitude accounts, the fittingness of the attitude is what value consists in. In Madhyasth Darshan, value consists in essentiality, and the attitude — sentiment, evaluation, taste — either tracks it or fails to. The darshan can therefore say that an entire tradition evaluates wrongly, which fitting-attitude accounts can say only by idealising the responses far enough to raise the question of what makes the idealisation correct.

3.5 Theories of well-being

The theories of what makes a life go well divide into hedonism, desire-satisfaction views, and objective-list or perfectionist views. Nozick's experience machine is the standard objection to hedonism: most people judge that a life of pleasant experience disconnected from reality goes worse, which suggests that something other than experiential quality matters. Desire-satisfaction views face the problem of ill-informed, adaptive, and self-destructive desires; objective lists face the charge of being unmotivated unless the items are tied to something about the person. Parfit's taxonomy and his discussion of "global" preferences remain the reference points.

Madhyasth Darshan's four harmonies (§1.2.2) function as an objective list with an unusual structural warrant: the items are not selected as plausibly good but read off the relations among *jeevan*'s faculties. Whether that warrant can be checked independently is a separate matter; what it does secure is an answer to the standard objection to objective lists, since the items are tied to the constitution of the subject whose life is at issue.

3.6 Pluralism, incommensurability, dignity, and price

Berlin argued that fundamental values genuinely conflict and that some losses cannot be compensated. Raz developed incommensurability as the failure of the comparative relations that a single scale would require, and Chang's work distinguishes several ways comparison can break down. Anderson's ex-

pressive theory holds that different goods call for different modes of valuation, so treating a good in the wrong mode is itself a failure. Kant's distinction between dignity and price is the classical version: what has dignity admits of no equivalent, and to price it is a category error rather than an undervaluation.

The convergences here are the strongest in this comparison. The study's non-substitutability reading of the *jeevan* values resembles incommensurability, and the treatment of money as symbolic value is close to Kant's point about price. Western pluralism often treats incommensurability as a source of tragic and rationally unresolvable conflict. Madhyasth Darshan's commitment to orderly coexistence instead suggests that apparent conflict should be re-examined for error of recognition or evaluation. The texts do not state a general theorem that every conflict among genuine values is resolvable (§7.7).

3.7 Material value-ethics: Scheler and Hartmann

Max Scheler's *Formalism in Ethics and Non-Formal Ethics of Values* is the closest structural counterpart to Madhyasth Darshan's axiology in modern Western thought, and the resemblance goes beyond terminology. Scheler holds that values are objective qualities rather than projections. They are grasped through *Wertfühlen*, an intentional feeling with its own cognitive adequacy, rather than through reason or sense. Values form a discovered hierarchy of sensory, vital, spiritual, and religious ranks. A value's endurance and independence of the body indicate its height. Scheler also gives a systematic account of evaluative error, including *Wertverblendung*, value-blindness, and *ressentiment*, in which the ranking is inverted rather than merely misapplied.

Nicolai Hartmann's *Ethics* develops the same programme with more attention to the criteria of height and to the tension between a value's height and its urgency — a distinction Scheler underplays and which the darshan's pairing of higher value with durability partly parallels.

The points of contact with §§1.4.2, 1.4.3, and 1.4.5 are exact enough to list. Both treat value as objective and non-natural in the physicalist sense. Both locate value-cognition in a non-inferential activity distinct from physical measurement, order values by rank rather than quantity, and treat durability as one mark of height. Both also develop characteristic evaluative failures and allow that an entire culture can invert value.

The differences are equally exact. Scheler's ranks are *a priori* essences given in feeling; the darshan's ranks derive from the participation of units in an orderly coexistence, so its account of why the ranking holds is ontological rather than phenomenological. Scheler's hierarchy culminates in the value of the holy; the darshan's culminates in coexistence and its realisation, and it has no category of the sacred to place at the top. And Scheler has no counterpart to the claim that correct evaluation requires an achieved transformation of the evaluator, which is where the darshan's axiology becomes inseparable from its account of awakening.

3.8 Economic value

Classical political economy separated use-value from exchange-value and sought the source of exchange-value in labour. Smith and Ricardo developed the labour theory that Marx used to argue that capitalist exchange-value systematically diverges from and dominates use-value. Money then func-

tions as the universal equivalent that makes qualitatively different goods commensurable. The marginalist revolution replaced this account with subjective utility at the margin, and twentieth-century economics reduced utility further to a representation of consistent preference through revealed preference theory.

Sen's critique is the pivotal modern intervention: utility conflates well-being with preference satisfaction, ignores adaptation, and cannot register what a person is actually able to do. The capability approach, developed with Nussbaum's account of central capabilities, replaces utility with the substantive freedoms a person has.

The darshan's treatment of usefulness, aesthetic addition, and symbolic value in §1.2.4 maps onto this history in a way that is neither classical nor marginalist. Usefulness value is close to use-value and is asserted to be constant, which no economic tradition accepts. Symbolic value is close to Marx's universal equivalent: a token of exchange comes to be treated as the thing of value. The darshan's remedy is not the abolition of a mode of production. It is exchange organised through recognition of labour value, with production oriented to assessed need.

3.9 Recognition, care, and trust

A final family locates value in relationship. Hegel's account of mutual recognition, developed by Honneth into a theory of recognition as the condition of self-realisation, holds that persons acquire practical standing only through being recognised by others. Care ethics takes the caring relation, rather than the autonomous agent, as the primary moral phenomenon. Philosophical work on trust treats it as a three-place attitude of dependence under vulnerability, with characteristic conditions of reasonableness and betrayal.

The overlap with §§1.3.1, 1.3.2, and 1.4.1 is substantial, and one difference is decisive. In these Western accounts, recognition or care partly *constitutes* the value at stake — being recognised is what confers standing. In Madhyasth Darshan, recognition is the discovery of a value already inherent in the relationship, and the relationship's inherent expectation exists whether or not either party recognises it. This is why the darshan can hold that unrecognised relationships fail while denying that value is conferred by recognition, and why its account of trust is a claim about fulfilment rather than about the reasonableness of an attitude.

3.10 Method, evidence, and what philosophy establishes

Western value theory establishes distinctions and constraints rather than results. Value cannot be straightforwardly identified with pleasure, desire-satisfaction, or market price. The passage from natural fact to evaluative conclusion needs an account, some goods resist comparison on one scale, and treating a good in the wrong mode is a distinct failure. The field has not converged on objectivity, and each family's epistemology of value inherits the problems of its metaphysics.

4. Modern Scientific Approaches

The sciences do not investigate value; they investigate valuation. That restriction is not a failing but a boundary, and keeping it visible is necessary if the convergences reported below are not to be over-read.

4.1 Valuation in the brain

Decision neuroscience has established that the brain computes something like a common currency. Dopaminergic activity in the midbrain encodes reward prediction error — the difference between received and expected reward — in a form well described by temporal-difference learning, and value signals correlating with subjective choice appear in ventromedial prefrontal and orbitofrontal cortex across widely different goods. Neuroeconomics reads these findings as evidence that heterogeneous options are converted into a comparable quantity before choice.

The result cuts two ways for axiology. It shows that the brain does something a single-scale theory of value predicts, which is a real difficulty for strong incommensurability claims. It equally shows that the quantity computed is a decision variable, not a measure of what is worth choosing: reward prediction error is defined against expectation, so the same objective outcome yields different signals depending on prior belief. Nothing in the neuroscience distinguishes valuing well from valuing badly.

4.2 Evolutionary accounts of valuing

Evolutionary biology explains why organisms value at all. Kin selection, reciprocal altruism, and the dynamics of repeated interaction account for cooperative dispositions without appeal to a moral faculty, and cross-cultural work has found that a small set of cooperative behaviours is positively valued across large samples of societies. Curry, Mullins, and Whitehouse's survey of sixty societies found no society in which cooperative behaviours were negatively valued.

Two interpretations of these findings compete. On the debunking reading, an evolutionary genealogy of our value judgments undercuts their claim to track anything beyond fitness. On the vindicating reading, cooperation is a real feature of social life and our capacity to recognise it is reliable for the same reason perception is. The evidence does not settle the choice, because the genealogy is compatible with both. What it does establish is that valuing is not culturally arbitrary — a conclusion that sits comfortably with the darshan's claim that human essentiality is universal, and equally comfortably with a purely naturalistic account of why it seems so.

4.3 Well-being science

Empirical well-being research has produced findings that bear directly on §1.2.2. Hedonic adaptation shows that many large changes in circumstance have transient effects on reported well-being. The Easterlin paradox — that within-country happiness has not risen with average income over long periods, even though richer individuals report higher happiness at a given time — remains contested but has not been dissolved. Kahneman and Deaton's separation of experienced from evaluative well-being found that emotional well-being ceases to rise with income above a threshold while life evaluation

continues to rise, which is direct evidence that at least two distinct things are being measured under one name.

Self-determination theory is the closest empirical analogue to the darshan's structural claim. It posits three basic psychological needs — autonomy, competence, and relatedness — whose satisfaction predicts well-being, and holds that they are not interchangeable: high competence does not compensate for thwarted relatedness. A body of evidence also shows that extrinsic goals such as wealth and status are associated with lower well-being even when attained.

The convergence is real but partial and should be stated carefully. Empirical work supports the claim that well-being is not a single quantity and that its components are not mutually substitutable. It does not support the specific fourfold division of happiness, peace, contentment, and bliss, and it does not identify any component with a harmony between named faculties. The darshan's account is consistent with the findings without being confirmed by them.

4.4 Trust and prosociality as measured goods

Social science treats trust as a measurable variable with substantial economic consequences: generalised trust correlates with growth, institutional quality, and lower transaction costs, and behavioural game theory has established robust patterns of conditional cooperation and costly punishment that simple self-interest models do not predict. This supports the darshan's placing of trust at the centre of social value while measuring something different from what the darshan defines (§1.3.2). Survey trust is an expectation about others; MVD's trust is the fulfilment of values inherent in mutuality (MVD, p. 336). The measured variable is closer to what the darshan would call the anticipation of fulfilment than to fulfilment itself.

4.5 Measurement, proxies, and their failure

Applied economics has documented the costs of measuring the wrong thing. GDP omits unpaid work, depletion of natural capital, and distribution; discount rates chosen for tractability determine conclusions about long-horizon harms; and preference-based welfare measures inherit whatever adaptation and misinformation shaped the preferences. The response has been a proliferation of alternative indices, none of which has displaced the original.

The persistence of this problem is independent evidence for a claim the darshan makes on other grounds: that a single scale imposed on plural values will misdirect the activity it is meant to guide.

4.6 Specification and alignment

The most recent independent evidence comes from machine learning. Goodhart's law — that a measure adopted as a target ceases to be a good measure — has been reproduced systematically in the study of reward hacking and specification gaming, where optimising systems reliably find policies that maximise a stated objective while defeating its purpose. Surveys of specification gaming catalogue dozens of instances, and the concrete-problems literature treats the difficulty of specifying objectives as a central obstacle rather than an engineering detail.

The structural lesson is exactly the one in §1.4.5: a proxy drawn from a lower evaluative domain, optimised without the standard that gives it its point, destroys the value it stood for. This is a convergence of some significance, since it arises from engineering practice with no philosophical commitments at all.

4.7 Method, evidence, and what science establishes

The sciences establish that valuation is a real, mechanistically describable process whose outputs have measurable biases. They show that well-being is not one quantity, plural goods resist aggregation in practice, and optimising proxies is dangerous. They do not establish what is valuable, and their methods are not constructed to. Where a finding appears to settle an axiological question, the appearance normally comes from a value premise already built into the chosen measure.

5. Comparison

5.1 Criteria for comparison

The four positions are compared on eight questions: what value is; where value resides; how value is known; whether values are commensurable; the standing of pleasure; the treatment of economic value; the final aim; and how a mistaken evaluation is corrected. These are chosen because each tradition takes a definite position on all eight, which is not true of finer-grained questions.

5.2 Cross-tradition summary

Question	Madhyasth Darshan	Advaita Vedanta	Modern Western philosophy	Natural and social sciences
What value is	The essentiality of a unit as it participates in coexistence	Finally, the Self as bliss; derivatively, what serves liberation	Contested: natural property, irreducible normative fact, construction, or attitude	Not addressed; valuation is a computed decision variable
Where value resides	In every unit; <i>jeevan</i> , human, and relational values are inherent in or expressed through <i>jeevan</i>	In the Self alone; apparent dearness in objects is misattributed	Varies by family: in objects, in attitudes, in agents' standpoints	In nervous systems and in populations of preferences

Question	Madhyasth Darshan	Advaita Vedanta	Modern Western philosophy	Natural and social sciences
How value is known	By <i>jeevan</i> , through the sentiment activity, correctly only under awakening	By <i>sruti</i> with reflection and contemplation, culminating in realisation	By intuition, reflective equilibrium, idealised response, or nothing	By measurement of choice, report, and physiology
Commensurability	Non-substitutable classes; higher and lower ranks with durability as mark of height	Radical asymmetry between <i>moksha</i> and everything else	Plural and often incommensurable; some traditions retain a single scale	Common currency at the point of choice; no scale for worth
Standing of pleasure	Real and legitimate in its domain; insufficient as an organising standpoint	Non-eternal, and therefore not the good	Hedonism a live but minority position; the experience machine its standard problem	A measurable component of well-being, subject to adaptation
Economic value	Usefulness constant; money symbolic only; accumulation the characteristic error	Wealth a legitimate but subordinate end	Use-value against exchange-value; utility; capabilities	Preference-based, with documented measurement failures
Final aim	Resolution, prosperity, fearlessness, coexistence — with the four harmonies	<i>Moksha</i> , already accomplished and merely to be recognised	No consensus; well-being, virtue, or autonomy on different accounts	Outside the domain
Correcting evaluation	Awakening, self-evaluation, and evidence in result and mutual satisfaction	Removal of ignorance by knowledge; <i>sublation</i> of the lower by the higher	Argument, reflective equilibrium, and appeal to considered judgments	Replication, debiasing, and better instruments

5.3 Locus of value

The four positions divide most sharply on where value is. Madhyasth Darshan distributes value across all units and makes *jeevan* the evaluator, not the source. Advaita concentrates all value in the Self and

treats its apparent distribution as error. Western philosophy is genuinely divided, and the division is what its metaethical debate is about. The sciences do not take a position, but their explanatory practice locates valuation in valuers, which functions as a default in favour of the view that value is conferred.

The consequence for relationships is the clearest test. Madhyasth Darshan holds that a relationship has an inherent expectation whether or not it is recognised; Advaita holds that the relata are finally unreal; recognition theories hold that standing is conferred by recognition; and the sciences describe relationships as arrangements that valuers value. Only the first supports the claim that a relationship can be failed by both parties without either noticing.

5.4 Objectivity and the is–ought gap

Advaita and Madhyasth Darshan are both value realists and reach that position by opposite routes: Advaita by denying that the plural world is real, Madhyasth Darshan by holding that value is what plural units essentially are. Neither accepts the framing in which an inference from fact to value must be licensed, because for neither is the evaluative fact a separate fact. Western philosophy takes the gap seriously and divides over whether it can be closed. The sciences accept it and stay on the factual side, which is why their results constrain axiology without settling it.

5.5 Commensurability and aggregation

All four positions reject a simple single scale, for different reasons. Madhyasth Darshan rejects it structurally, because its values are harmonies between distinct pairs of faculties. Advaita rejects it asymmetrically, because the highest value differs in kind from all others. Western pluralism rejects it on the strength of conflict cases and the failure of comparative relations. Applied science rejects it empirically, because proxies chosen for aggregation demonstrably misdirect the activity they measure.

Yet the darshan and Western pluralism orient themselves differently to conflict. Berlin's incommensurability allows that some conflicts are tragic and rationally unresolvable. Madhyasth Darshan's account of orderly coexistence directs the evaluator to search for failures of recognition, fulfilment, or evaluation before accepting a final conflict. Whether this commits the darshan to the stronger claim that every conflict among genuine values is resolvable is an interpretive question, and §7.7 asks whether the texts provide an adequate procedure.

5.6 Value ranks: Madhyasth Darshan and Scheler

The two closest positions in this comparison deserve their own contrast. Both hold that values are objective and ranked, that value-cognition is non-inferential, that height is bound up with durability, and that whole traditions can invert the ranking. They differ in three respects. Scheler grounds the ranks in *a priori* value essences apprehended in feeling; Madhyasth Darshan grounds them in the participation of units in an orderly coexistence, giving it an ontological rather than phenomenological warrant. Scheler's hierarchy ends in the holy; the darshan's ends in coexistence and has no sacred category. And Scheler's value-cognition is available to ordinary intentional feeling, while the darshan requires an achieved transformation of the evaluator, which makes its axiology dependent on its account of awakening in a way Scheler's is not.

The comparison also shows what the darshan gains from its ontology. Scheler must explain why the ranks are as described when their evidence is the feeling that discloses them. Madhyasth Darshan can point to resolved outlook, durability, awakening, and participation in orderliness. How these marks combine remains unsettled (§§1.4.5, 7.1), and their accessibility raises the circularity examined in §7.2.

5.7 Kinds of value in the economy

The darshan's usefulness value, aesthetic addition, and symbolic value (§1.2.4) line up against use-value, exchange-value, utility, and capability without matching any of them. Its critique of money as symbolic value shares Marx's structure — a token of exchange usurping the place of the thing valued — without the theory of exploitation or the historical account of modes of production. Its constancy claim for usefulness value is stronger than anything in classical economics and is in tension with the marginalist point that usefulness at the margin varies with quantity and context. Its orientation of production to assessed need is closer to the capability approach than to either classical or neoclassical economics, since both the darshan and Sen refuse to let realised preference stand as the measure of what people should be able to do.

5.8 Partially incommensurable criteria of evaluation

The traditions do not merely disagree about values; they disagree about what would settle a disagreement. For Madhyasth Darshan the evidence is fulfilment in relationship, evaluated result, and mutual satisfaction sustained across a tradition. For Advaita it is realisation of the Self, before which relational evidence is provisional. For Western philosophy it is argument tested against considered judgments. For the sciences it is replicable measurement.

None of these can be substituted for another without loss. Mutual satisfaction is not a replicable measurement, and a replicable measurement of reported satisfaction is not the fulfilment of a relationship's inherent expectation. This is why the comparison in §5.2 can be stated but not adjudicated by a neutral procedure — a limitation this study shares with [The Epistemology of Coexistence](#) §5.3, and one worth stating rather than papering over.

6. Critical Review

6.1 Madhyasth Darshan — a coherent value realism with an undischarged criterion

Strengths.

- Value is derived from the ontology directly (§§1.1.1–1.1.2) rather than added to it, so the darshan reframes the is–ought problem instead of inferring value from a value-neutral description.
- The definitions are unusually operational for a value theory. Trust is fulfilment, not confidence, and dispassion is evaluative accuracy, not indifference. Kindness, grace, and compassion are separated by the objective condition of the recipient rather than by the agent's feeling. Relationship is separated from contact by whether expectations are predetermined or voluntary

(§1.3.1). These distinctions give value-fulfilment a subject matter independent of what the parties happen to agree.

- The MVD appendix's pairings of established and *shishta* values (§1.3.2) provide a bridge between relational acceptance and civilised conduct.
- The distinct four harmonies (§1.2.2) support a principled non-substitutability reading rather than treating well-being as one undifferentiated quantity.
- The three failure modes of evaluation — over, under, and mis (§1.4.2) — give a taxonomy of moral error that does not reduce to weakness of will, ignorance of fact, or bad rules, and that applies to whole traditions as readily as to individuals.
- The account of value transmission is consistent with its axiology: higher value attracts, glory is emulation without resistance, and value education is the social form of both. Nothing has to be added to explain why understanding should spread.

Weaknesses.

- The correctness criterion is not independently exercisable. Correct evaluation requires awakening; awakening is evidenced by correct evaluation, fulfilled relationships, and mutual satisfaction. The circle is not vicious as a description of an integrated life, but it does not adjudicate a disputed case.
- The rooting chain of §1.4.4 is stated as a closed cycle without an account of how any member can be corrected from outside it.
- Mutual satisfaction is doing heavy evidential work while remaining unspecified as a public test. The darshan gives no procedure for the case where both parties are satisfied and a third party judges the relationship exploitative, or where satisfaction is asymmetric by long habituation.
- The constancy of usefulness value is asserted rather than argued and is in tension with ordinary facts about scarcity, substitution, and technological change.
- JV names nine relationship values without deriving an exhaustive list from the taxonomy of §1.2.1. The account does not say whether the examples are complete or what would settle a proposal to add another.
- The stronger interpretation that no conflict among genuine values is finally irresolvable is not supported by a decision procedure.

Madhyasth Darshan offers the most fully integrated value theory of the four positions examined here, and its integration is purchased by making the criterion of correct evaluation internal to the transformation it recommends.

6.2 Advaita Vedanta — a secure ultimate value, a thin relational one

Strengths.

- The argument that a value which can be gained and lost cannot be the final good is rigorous and has never been satisfactorily answered by eudaimonist or hedonist accounts.

- The Maitreyi teaching gives a unified explanation of why finite goods both attract unconditionally and disappoint, which competing theories explain only piecemeal.
- Locating the highest value in what one already is removes the regress that afflicts accounts in which the good must be produced.
- The qualification structure states plainly what a seeker must already possess, rather than treating value-recognition as available on demand.

Weaknesses.

- Relational value has no secure ground. If the relata are finally unreal, the value of a fulfilled relationship cannot be final, and *loka-sangraha* explains why the liberated act without explaining why the relationship matters.
- The tradition's account of empirical value is largely negative, so it has little to say about how competing legitimate goods should be ordered within the world.
- The bliss identification is textually secure but resists any independent check, since the evidence for it is realisation and the criterion of realisation is given within the tradition.

Advaita secures the ultimate value more tightly than any other position considered here and pays for it with the provisionality of everything else.

6.3 Modern Western axiology — sharp distinctions without a settled ground

Strengths.

- The distinctions are genuine advances: intrinsic against final value, value against reasons, height against urgency, dignity against price, modes of valuation against amounts of value.
- The negative results are robust. Value is not identical with pleasure, with satisfied preference, or with market price, and each of these has been shown to fail by argument rather than assertion.
- Value pluralism and incommensurability are developed with a precision no other tradition matches, and Scheler and Hartmann show that an objective ranked axiology can be worked out in detail.
- The field is self-correcting: each family's difficulties are stated by its own proponents.

Weaknesses.

- The objectivity question is no closer to resolution than it was a century ago, and each family's epistemology of value inherits its metaphysics' problems.
- Fitting-attitude and response-dependent accounts have difficulty explaining large-scale evaluative error without idealising responses to the point where the correctness of the idealisation becomes the original question.
- The separation of questions that gives the field its rigour also leaves it without an integrated account: theories of well-being, of moral obligation, and of economic value are pursued largely independently.

Western axiology has mapped the space of positions more carefully than any other tradition and has not established which of them to hold.

6.4 Natural and social sciences — real measurement of valuation, no verdict on value

Strengths.

- The mechanisms of valuation are genuinely known in outline, and the finding that valuation is computed against expectation explains a large class of evaluative errors.
- Well-being research has established empirically that well-being is not one quantity, supporting a claim philosophy could only argue for.
- The evolutionary and cross-cultural evidence shows that valuing is not arbitrary, which constrains relativist positions.
- The specification and alignment literature supplies independent, practical evidence that optimising a proxy destroys the value it stood for.

Weaknesses.

- The methods measure valuation and cannot distinguish valuing well from valuing badly; every apparent verdict on value comes from a value premise in the choice of measure.
- The common-currency finding is often over-read as showing that value is single-scaled, when it shows only that choice requires comparison.
- Adaptation results are frequently presented as showing that circumstances do not matter, which does not follow from the transience of reported affect.
- Debunking and vindicating readings of the evolutionary evidence are both consistent with it, and the science cannot choose between them.

The sciences constrain axiology substantially and settle none of its questions, which is what their methods were built to do.

7. Open problems for Madhyasth Darshan axiology

7.1 The structure of the higher–lower ordering

The darshan uses two apparatuses: six perspectives classified as inhumane or humane, and a comparative ranking of higher and lower value (§1.4.5). The texts do not settle whether these form one ordering or two. A single ordering would resemble a scale and would require an account of why it is not a maximand. A domain-relative ordering would need to explain cross-domain comparisons, such as prosperity gained at the cost of trust. Defining higher value as resolved outlook and lower value as problem-orientation suggests one ordering by tendency towards resolution. That reading is also in greatest tension with the non-substitutability of the four harmonies.

7.2 Value realism and the awareness-dependence of evaluation

The darshan asserts both that value is established in every unit (SB, p. 87) and that in the absence of awareness there is no determination of value (KD, p. 23). Taken as a distinction between value and its determination, the pair is coherent and is the position defended in §1.4.6. What remains open is whether the darshan can identify a correct determination without already assuming the awakening that is supposed to guarantee it. The rooting chain of §1.4.4 closes the circle explicitly. A response is available in principle — that convergent evidence from result, relationship, and tradition constrains evaluation from several directions at once — but the texts do not develop it, and its development is the most valuable work an interpreter could do here.

7.3 Mutual satisfaction as public evidence

Mutual satisfaction is the terminus of justice (MVD, p. 336) and therefore the darshan's principal public evidence that value has been fulfilled. The definiteness of a relationship's expectations (§1.3.1) is what makes the question well posed, since without it there would be nothing for satisfaction to be satisfaction *of*. Three cases are unaddressed. Where both parties are satisfied and an outside observer judges the relationship exploitative, the darshan must either accept the parties' verdict or appeal to a standard beyond satisfaction, and it does not say which. Where satisfaction is asymmetric because one party's expectations have been shaped downward by long habituation, satisfaction registers the adaptation rather than the fulfilment. And where a relationship's obligations extend to parties not present — future generations, distant others — mutual satisfaction has no purchase. The first two are the problems that adaptive preference raises for preference-based welfare theory (§3.8), arriving by a different route.

7.4 Does participation derive value or presuppose it?

Identifying value with essentiality and locating human value in participation in orderliness dissolves the is–ought problem only if “orderliness” is not itself an evaluative term. If orderliness means whatever pattern obtains, then participation in it carries no normative weight. If it means the pattern in which units reach completeness and coexistence is sustained, then the value is already in the description, and the darshan has offered a definition rather than a derivation. The texts point to the second, and the definition may be a good one; but the darshan should not also claim to have crossed the is–ought gap, since on this reading it has declined to enter it. The comparison with neo-Aristotelian naturalism in §3.2 faces the same question in the same form.

7.5 The constancy of usefulness value

The claim that a kilogram of sesame seeds has always had the same value (JV, p. 137) is the darshan's most exposed empirical assertion. Read as saying that the object's own capacities do not change with market conditions, it is defensible and is a real corrective to price-based thinking. Read as saying that usefulness itself is constant, it faces obvious counter-cases: usefulness depends on available technique, on what else is available, on quantity already held, and on the purpose in view. Antibiotics lose useful-

ness as resistance spreads; a fuel loses usefulness when the engines that burn it are gone. The darshan needs the first reading, and the texts do not clearly distinguish it from the second.

7.6 The status of the nine named relationship values

JV, p. 108 names nine values using the phrase “such as,” and MVD’s appendix defines and pairs each of them. The passage does not call the set exhaustive or derive it from the taxonomy of value classes (§1.2.1). The appendix narrows the question without closing it. Each of the nine occupies a position in the enumeration of *jeevan*’s activities (§1.3.2), so a proposal to add a tenth relationship value has to name the position that would bear it — a checkable demand rather than an appeal to intuition. What stays open is the completeness of the enumeration itself: the per-faculty counts are printed with the tabulation and nowhere argued, and the same block of positions carries relational names that are not among the nine. Whether the nine are the enumeration’s full set of relationship values or a selection from a wider relational group is therefore undetermined.

7.7 Conflict between two just claims

The orderliness of coexistence encourages the expectation that apparent value conflicts can be resolved by correcting recognition, fulfilment, or evaluation (§5.5). The texts nevertheless need a procedure for cases where two recognised relationships make incompatible claims and both fulfilments appear just. They supply the widening chain from justice to *dharma* to truth, which locates where the question should be reconsidered, but not a method for deciding. Without such a method, the stronger interpretation that every residual conflict indicates an undiscovered error risks becoming unfalsifiable.

7.8 The transmission circle

Value education is the darshan’s mechanism for making correct evaluation available, and correct evaluation is what qualifies a person to conduct it. This is the axiological form of the problem identified in [The Epistemology of Coexistence](#) §7.5. The darshan’s own resources for addressing it are the natural attraction of lower value towards higher value (MVD, p. 222) and glory as emulation without resistance (MVD, p. 335) — mechanisms that require no prior qualification in the learner. Whether they suffice to bootstrap a tradition, and how they are to be distinguished from ordinary prestige-following, is not worked out.

7.9 Value in the other orders and the boundary of right-use

Holding that value is established in every unit gives the darshan a strong basis for right-use and a corresponding difficulty in drawing its boundary. If a plant, a mineral, and an animal each have essentiality that is their value, the darshan needs to say why using them is not a violation of that value, and why some uses are right and others exploitative. The available answer is that right-use is participation in the orderliness in which each order finds completeness, with regeneration as the measure (SB, p. 141). That is a real criterion, and it is not obviously sufficient to settle the harder cases — animal use, habitat conversion, and the treatment of the animal order in particular, given the darshan’s own position on vegetarian food (SB, p. 201).

7.10 Translation load on *mulya* and *bhav*

Mulya carries value, worth, and price in the source language, and the translations render it by all three. *Bhav* is rendered as sentiment, value, and meaning in different passages, and MVD's glossary defines it as "Value, evaluation" (MVD, p. 326) while the rooting chain (§1.4.4) treats sentiment and evaluation as distinct members of one series. Readers of the English texts can easily take a claim about *bhav* as psychological when it is axiological, or take the constancy of *mulya* as a claim about price. The Editorial Notes below record the conventions adopted here.

8. Conclusion

Madhyasth Darshan holds that value is the essentiality of a unit in coexistence and is therefore established in every unit. Evaluation occurs through *jeevan*: the animal order recognises essential nature, while the human knowledge order can evaluate fulfilment explicitly and correct evaluation through awakening. Values in relationship are recognised rather than created, and justice proceeds through recognition, fulfilment, evaluation, and mutual satisfaction. The four *jeevan* values name distinct harmonies, supporting a plural rather than simply scalar account of fulfilment. The separate higher–lower ordering nevertheless leaves the precise structure of that plurality open.

The system's integration is its strength and the source of its principal difficulty. Because the criterion of correct evaluation is essentiality, and essentiality is accessible only to an evaluator who has achieved awakening, the darshan cannot exhibit its criterion to someone who does not already share its account of the evaluator. Mutual satisfaction, evaluated result, and humane tradition are offered as public evidence, and they are genuine constraints; they are not yet a procedure for adjudicating a disputed evaluation, and the texts do not supply one.

Set against the other positions, the darshan makes three distinctive contributions. It grounds objective value in an ontology rather than in phenomenology or intuition, separating it from Scheler's closely parallel system. It combines plural forms of value with an orientation towards orderly coexistence, treating conflict as a reason to re-examine recognition and evaluation without supplying a universal decision procedure. It also treats value as real throughout the non-human orders while assigning reflective, correct, and publicly communicable evaluation to awakened human living. This gives right-use a basis that is neither merely instrumental nor an extension of human rights language.

The central open question is whether the criterion can be exercised in disputed cases. Advaita secures its highest value by making everything else provisional. Western axiology maps alternatives without convergence, and the sciences measure valuation without deciding what is valuable. Madhyasth Darshan answers directly and stakes correct evaluation on transformation of the evaluator. That is a substantive claim about human beings, not merely a definition; its survival under disagreement remains to be shown.

Appendix: Quick Glossary

Terms in §1

- **Mulya** — value. In this darshan the essentiality of a unit as it participates in coexistence, not a preference, a price, or a conferred property.
- **Maulikta** — essentiality, fundamental distinctiveness. What a unit distinctively is in the whole; identified with value at SB, p. 50.
- **Mulyankan** — evaluation. Recognition or determination of essential nature through *jeevan*; in human living, evaluation also tests whether value has been fulfilled.
- **Bhav-kriya** — sentiment activity. The single activity comprising values and their evaluation (MVD, p. 203).
- **Bhav** — sentiment; glossed in MVD's appendix as "Value, evaluation" (MVD, p. 326).
- **Vastu mulya** — object value. The usefulness of a physical unit or produced object; described as "spread everywhere."
- **Upyogita mulya** — usefulness value. The constant value of an object for a purpose.
- **Prateek mulya** — symbolic value. Money as token of exchange; accumulable and not the value of any object.
- **Kala / saundarya mulya** — aesthetic value; convenience added to usefulness in produced objects.
- **Jeevan mulya** — the four values of *jeevan*: happiness, peace, contentment, bliss, as harmonies between adjacent faculties.
- **Manav mulya** — human values. The *dharma* and essential nature of the human being as such.
- **Sthapit mulya** — established values. Values inherent in recognised relationships; JV names nine examples.
- **Shishta mulya** — *shishta* or civic values. Civilised expressions paired with established values in MVD's appendix.
- **Guru mulya / *laghu mulya*** — higher and lower value. Ranked by tendency towards resolution and by durability of result, not by intensity.
- **Avamulyan / adhimulyan / *amulyan*** — under-evaluation, over-evaluation, and mis-evaluation; the three failure modes of the sentiment activity.
- **Swa-mulyankan** — self-evaluation; the first step in human development, undertaken against human essentiality and coexistence.
- **Abhiman** — conceit. Imposed evaluation, characterised by the three failure modes.
- **Asakti** — attachment. Believing mistakes made towards decline to be correct.
- **Ubhaya sukrti / *ubhaya vikrti*** — mutual ascent and mutual descent. Movement towards higher value with durability, or towards lower value with short-lasting result.
- **Pratikranti** — retrogression. Movement towards mutual descent upon coming together.

- **Nirvah** — fulfilling. Evidencing use, right-use, and purposeful-use, or proving mutual complementariness.
- **Pahchan** — recognition. Identifying a relationship and its inherent purpose, without which values do not flow.
- **Kshamata, yogyata, *patrata*** — capacity, ability, receptivity. The conditions that mediate whether a recognised value is actually fulfilled.
- **Ubhaya tripti** — mutual satisfaction. The terminus of justice and the darshan's principal public evidence of value-fulfilment.
- **Sadupyog** — right-use. Use that serves the purpose for which a resource has value, within regeneration.
- **Daya, kripa, *karuna*** — kindness, grace, compassion; distinguished by whether the recipient lacks content, receptivity, or both (MVD, p. 61).
- **Samajikta** — sociality. Fulfilling the values inherent in relationships and contacts (MVD, p. 56).
- **Sambandh** — relationship. A mutuality whose expectations are predetermined in the sense of completeness (MVD, p. 62); the seven forms are enumerated at MVD, p. 190.
- **Sampark** — contact. A mutuality whose expectations are voluntary (MVD, p. 61); contrasted with *sambandh*, not ranked below it.
- **Sanskar** — acceptances towards completeness, and the knowledge and tendencies carried forward for evidencing; named the cause of awakening of the sentient aspect (MVD, p. 90).
- **Susanskar / *kusanskar** — sanskar* under awakening and under delusion (MVD, pp. 94, 315); the mechanism by which conduct deepens or entrenches understanding.

Terms in §2

- **Purushartha** — human end. *Dharma, artha, kama*, and *moksha*, with *moksha* as the highest.
- **Ananda** — bliss. In Advaita, the nature of Brahman rather than a state produced by action.
- **Priyata** — dearness. In BU 2.4.5, traced to the Self as its single source.
- **Sadhana-chatushtaya** — the fourfold qualification: *viveka, vairagya*, the six treasures, and *mumukshutva*.
- **Vairagya** — dispassion as turning away from the non-eternal; contrast MVD's definition as freedom from the three evaluative flaws.
- **Loka-sangraha** — the holding-together of the world; the ground of the liberated person's continued action.
- **Mithya** — neither real nor unreal; the status of the world at the level of final truth.

Terms in §3

- **Intrinsic and final value** — valuable in virtue of intrinsic properties; valuable for its own sake. Distinguished in later work on Moore.
- **Organic unity** — a whole whose value is not the sum of its parts' values.

- **Open question argument** — Moore’s objection that for any natural analysis of goodness it remains open whether what satisfies it is good.
- **Fitting-attitude account** — the view that to be valuable is to be a fitting object of pro-attitudes.
- **Buck-passing** — Scanlon’s view that being valuable is not itself reason-giving but indicates that other properties give reasons.
- **Incommensurability** — the failure of the comparative relations a single scale would require.
- **Dignity and price** — Kant’s distinction between what admits of no equivalent and what has one.
- **Wertfühlen** — Scheler’s value-feeling: intentional feeling with its own cognitive adequacy.
- **Value-inversion** — Scheler’s account of a ranking systematically reversed, as in *ressentiment*.
- **Use-value and exchange-value** — what a good does; what it trades for.
- **Capability** — Sen’s measure of what a person is actually able to do and be.

Terms in §4

- **Reward prediction error** — the difference between received and expected reward, encoded by dopaminergic activity.
- **Common currency** — a comparable quantity into which heterogeneous options are converted before choice.
- **Hedonic adaptation** — the return of reported well-being towards baseline after changes in circumstance.
- **Easterlin paradox** — the absence of long-run within-country gains in reported happiness alongside rising income.
- **Experienced and evaluative well-being** — momentary affect against reflective life assessment.
- **Self-determination theory** — the account of autonomy, competence, and relatedness as non-substitutable basic needs.
- **Goodhart’s law** — a measure adopted as a target ceases to be a good measure.
- **Specification gaming** — optimising a stated objective in a way that defeats its purpose.

Editorial Notes

Translating *mulya*

Mulya is rendered as “value” throughout the analytical prose of this study, reserving “price” for monetary exchange and “worth” for no technical use. The Rakesh Gupta translations use “value” for the axiological sense and occasionally “usefulness” as a gloss in the object-value passages; block quotes keep the translation’s wording. Where a passage could be read as making a claim about price, this is flagged in the surrounding prose (§§1.2.4, 7.5).

Relationship (*sambandh*) and contact (*sampark*)

The Rakesh Gupta English translation of MVD occasionally uses “association” for *sampark*. To maintain clarity across this series of studies and distinguish voluntary-expectation mutuality from general social organizations or voluntary groupings, *sampark* is systematically translated as “contact” (MVD, p. 61), while *sambandh* is translated as “relationship” (MVD, p. 62). Contact is a distinct, valid form of mutuality whose expectations are voluntary, contrasted with relationship (whose expectations are predetermined in the sense of completeness), and is not a lesser or defective status (KD, p. 20).

Bhav as sentiment, value, and meaning

MVD’s appendix defines *bhav* as “Value, evaluation” (MVD, p. 326), while the rooting chain at MVD, p. 83 treats sentiment and evaluation as distinct members of one series. MVD, p. 125 also states “Sentiment = Essentiality.” This study takes the appendix definition as systematic: *bhav* names axiological content and its determination together. It reads the rooting chain as analysing dependent moments of that activity rather than separate faculties. “Sentiment” remains the running English term because the translations use it, but it carries no merely psychological or affective implication here.

The seven relationships

JV, p. 108 refers to “the seven relationships” without listing them; MVD, p. 190 enumerates seven forms — parent and child, sibling, spousal, master and associate, teacher and student, friendship, and orderliness. This study treats the enumeration as the referent of JV’s phrase, which is the natural reading and matches the count, though neither passage states the correspondence. The parenthetical groupings and purposes in the §1.3.1 table are drawn from the surrounding definitions of relationship and purpose, not from a single list in the sources.

The nine named relationship values and their pairings

JV, p. 108 names care, guidance, trust, affection, gratitude, glory, love, reverence, and respect using the phrase “such as.” MVD’s appendix defines each beside a paired term, and MVD elsewhere names established and *shishta* values together. This study preserves those primary-text pairings while not treating the nine examples as an explicitly exhaustive list; §7.6 records the unresolved status of the set. Because the pairing is fixed by the appendix rather than assembled by the study, a table that gave one of the nine a different expression would not be a translation variant but a departure from the source; the §1.3.2 pairings are therefore the ones to follow across the series.

The enumerated activities of *jeevan*

MVD’s appendix enumerates two activities of *atma*, four of *buddhi*, sixteen of *chitta*, thirty-six of *vritti*, and sixty-four of *mun* (MVD, pp. 328–343), alongside eight activities of visualisation within *chitta* (MVD, p. 327). Read as pairs, the same enumeration is sixty-one positions carrying a hundred and twenty-two activities, and the AVD tabulation fixes which member of each position is borne in state and which carries it outward (AVD, pp. 91–94). It defines activities, states, relations, and paired

expressions; not every item is a separate value. These expand the ten named activities of *jeevan* used in [The Ontology of Coexistence](#) §1.7 rather than forming a rival enumeration.

This study uses the enumeration to locate a named value and its expression, not to explain how the value works. The definitions do not divide uniformly across the two columns of a position, no general rule is stated for how the outward member stands to the one borne in state, and the per-faculty counts are printed rather than argued. Those unresolved points are recorded position by position in [The Sixty-One Activity Pairs of Jeevan](#), and nothing in this study's axiology depends on their resolution.

“Constant” object value

The constancy asserted at JV, p. 137 is read here as constancy of the object's own capacity to serve a purpose, not as constancy of usefulness in every context. The passage does not itself draw the distinction; §7.5 sets out why the study adopts the narrower reading and what the wider one would cost.

Value in Western axiology and in Madhyasth Darshan

“Value” in Western axiology is a normative property or relation whose bearer and grounding are contested. In Madhyasth Darshan it is the essentiality of a unit, which makes it a fact about the unit's being rather than a further property. The mapping used in §§3 and 5 aligns the two only for the purpose of comparison; no claim is made that a single concept is at work.

Citation of KD

Manav Karm Darshan is cited from the working English translation held in this repository, using its page markers. That translation is not a published edition; its formulations, particularly in the front matter and *Foreword* from which several axiological statements in §1 are drawn, should be checked against the Hindi before being relied on for close argument.

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110); essential nature as value of self, and attachment (p. 124); *dharma* and essential nature of humans, sentiment as essentiality (p. 125); higher value as resolved outlook (p. 126); dispassion as freedom from the three flaws (p. 152); refinement in *susanskar* through enlightenment about the human goal and *jeevan* values (p. 187); the seven forms of relationship and the three kinds of conferred rights (p. 190); money as symbolic value (p. 183); conceit (p. 185); sentiment activity and the three failure modes of evaluation (p. 203); ascension and descension cause (p. 219); study and *susanskar* as conditions of *dharma*-oriented desire (p. 292); *susanskar* and *kusanskar* (p. 315); followership and higher value (p. 220); lower value attracted to higher value (p. 222); appendix enumerations of the activities of *jeevan* and their values (pp. 326–343), including visualisation (p. 327), *atma* and *buddhi* (p. 328), *chitta* (p. 329), love, contentment, and abundance (p. 331), guidance, reverence, and *vritti* (p. 332), peace with kindness (p. 333), trust, gratitude, and glory with their expressions (p. 335), care and *mun* (p. 339), respect, affection, and generosity (p. 340), happiness with motivation (p. 346); trust and justice as the four-step sequence (p. 336); justice (p. 311); ultimate bliss at realised *atma* and its effect through the remaining faculties (pp. 100–101); the definitions of the activities of *jeevan* to the close of the appendix, including the harmony positions and the established, civic, and human value positions (pp. 328–348).

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- **BG** — [Bhagavad Gita with the Commentary of Shankaracharya](#). English translation by Swami Gambhirananda. Cited: prescribed action without attachment to fruit (3.8); *loka-sangraha* and action by the enlightened (3.20, 3.25–26); divine qualities (16.2–16.3).
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- [The Ontology of Coexistence](#) — form, properties, essential nature and *dharma* (§1.3), the four orders (§1.5), *jeevan* faculties (§1.7), evaluative perspectives and the dual role of justice (§§1.12–1.12.1), and the four goals with the five social dimensions (§1.15).
- [The Epistemology of Coexistence](#) — knowing, believing, recognising, fulfilling, evaluating, karma, and evaluated result (§1.5), and the transmission problem (§7.5).
- [Ethics and Morals in Human Beings](#) — the six perspectives as an ethical hierarchy (§3.2), and character and right-use (§§3.5–3.6).
- [Aesthetics](#) — usefulness and the aesthetic addition (§4.1), and taste as the savouring of values (§4.5).
- [Human Behavior and Society](#) — why human fulfilment is not a scalar variable, and the limits of optimisation (§§2.1.1–2.1.6).

- [How to Form Self-Sustaining Organizations](#) — organisations grounded in fear or accumulation, and the alternative.
- *Prosperity Economics and Right Use* (Ongoing) — production, exchange, cyclical economics, and the limits of accumulation, developing §1.2.4.
- *Family Relationships and Values* (Ongoing) — the seven relationships and the individual established values as they are lived in family living, developing §§1.3.1–1.3.2.
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